



TRACES

72-STATEMENT ASSESSMENT

January 2026

Trauma and Relational Adversity in Caregiver Environments (TRACEs) Assessment

An Assessment for Trauma Activation in Multi-Systemic Caregiving

Welcome to the TRACEs Assessment—a tool developed to support parents and caregivers navigating the complex, emotionally demanding role of raising youth involved in multiple systems. The Assessment is designed to identify signs of caregiver strain, systemic overwhelm, and trauma activation, helping teams respond with meaningful, compassionate, and coordinated support.

Purpose of the Assessment

The TRACEs Assessment offers a focused lens on the invisible burdens carried by caregivers of multi-system-involved youth. By highlighting patterns of relational stress, system fatigue, and emotional depletion, the Assessment helps providers, peer supporters, and care teams understand when a caregiver may need stabilization, collaborative planning, or deeper conversation.

Structure of the Assessment

The Screener is structured around six trauma-responsive domains that impact caregiver well-being:

- Parent-to-Child Impact
- Spousal/Nuclear Family Impact
- Extended Family Impact
- Social/Community Impact (School, Medical Provider Offices, Places of Worship, etc.)
- Financial Strain
- Household Safety

Using the Screener

The Full TRACEs Assessment contains 72 questions across six domains using a 0–4 Likert scale. This comprehensive tool provides detailed insight into the degree and location of caregiver trauma.

Use the Full Assessment when:

- You have 45–60 minutes for comprehensive assessment
- The Short-Form indicates significant trauma activation
- You're developing a detailed care plan or service coordination strategy
- You need to measure progress over time
- The caregiver wants a deeper exploration of their experience

Trauma and Relational Adversity in Caregiver Environments (TRACES) - Assessment

General Family Information

Parent/Caregiver Name:

Youth Name:

Phone Number:

Email Address:

Caregiver Type (Circle One): Biological Parent Foster/Kinship Placement Adoptive Other

Youth Age Group (Circle One): 0-7 Early Childhood 8-13 Youth 14-18 Transitional

Does your child have a disability (Circle One): Yes No

Which Systems of Care is your family currently involved with?

- ☐ Juvenile Justice
- ☐ Child Welfare
- ☐ Disability Support Services
- ☐ Complex Medical Needs
- ☐ School Disciplinary/Truancy
- ☐ Mental/Behavioral Health
- ☐ Interdisciplinary Wraparound Care
- ☐ Adult Justice
- ☐ Individualized Education Plan (IEP or 504 Plan)

1. Parent to Child Impact (12 Questions)

How much do you feel these statements reflect your present situation?

I find it challenging to understand and respond to my child's needs.	0	1	2	3	4
I struggle to manage my child's challenging behaviors effectively.	0	1	2	3	4
We rarely have meaningful conversations, which hinders our connection.	0	1	2	3	4
My child hesitates to share their problems with me.	0	1	2	3	4
I find it difficult to recognize and praise my child's good behavior.	0	1	2	3	4
I often feel overwhelmed and under-resourced in my parenting responsibilities.	0	1	2	3	4
Managing stress and anxiety related to parenting is a challenge for me.	0	1	2	3	4
Our communication often lacks a strong, positive connection.	0	1	2	3	4
I feel that the challenges of parenting are hindering my personal growth.	0	1	2	3	4
Our bond feels strained, impacting our relationship.	0	1	2	3	4
Meeting my child's emotional needs is often a struggle for me.	0	1	2	3	4
My child's behavior rarely reflects the values and teachings I try to impart.	0	1	2	3	4

Total: _____

2. Spousal/Nuclear Family Impact (12 Questions)

How much do you feel these statements reflect your present situation?

Conflicts due to parenting disagreements frequently arise in our family.	0	1	2	3	4
Our parenting styles clash, causing tension within the family.	0	1	2	3	4
Our child's needs and behaviors have strained my relationship with my partner.	0	1	2	3	4
We struggle to find time for quality family activities.	0	1	2	3	4
Aligning on parenting strategies with my partner is challenging.	0	1	2	3	4
We have sought external support or counseling for our parenting challenges.	0	1	2	3	4
Changes and challenges disrupt our family routines significantly.	0	1	2	3	4
I often feel unsupported and undervalued by my partner in our parenting journey.	0	1	2	3	4
Parenting stress has negatively impacted our family's overall happiness.	0	1	2	3	4
We rarely have the opportunity to enjoy shared family activities.	0	1	2	3	4
My physical or mental well-being is negatively affected by parenting stress.	0	1	2	3	4
Facing parenting challenges has not contributed to our family's resilience.	0	1	2	3	4

Total: _____

3. Extended Family Impact (12 Questions)

How much do you feel these statements reflect your present situation?

Our extended family is not supportive of our parenting approach.	0	1	2	3	4
My child's behavior creates tension with extended family members.	0	1	2	3	4
Involvement with extended family often leads to more stress rather than well-being.	0	1	2	3	4
Family gatherings are a significant source of stress due to my child's behavior.	0	1	2	3	4
We receive little practical help with child-rearing from extended family members.	0	1	2	3	4
Extended family lacks understanding and acceptance of my child's needs.	0	1	2	3	4
We seldom seek or receive valuable parenting advice from extended family.	0	1	2	3	4
Extended family members are not empathetic or informed about our child's needs.	0	1	2	3	4
I frequently need to explain or defend my parenting choices to extended family.	0	1	2	3	4
I often feel judged and misunderstood by extended family members in my parenting role.	0	1	2	3	4
Childcare support from extended family is rarely available or helpful.	0	1	2	3	4
Extended family gatherings often make things worse rather than help parenting stress.	0	1	2	3	4

Total: _____

4. Social/Community Impact (12 Questions)

How much do you feel these statements reflect your present situation?

I often feel isolated from my community due to my child's needs or behaviors.	0	1	2	3	4
My child's school district is difficult to work with.	0	1	2	3	4
Accessible and helpful community resources are difficult to find for our family.	0	1	2	3	4
My child's needs have significantly limited my social activities.	0	1	2	3	4
I often feel judged or misunderstood by others in my community.	0	1	2	3	4
My child struggles significantly with making friends or social interactions.	0	1	2	3	4
Participating in community events with my child is a challenge for me.	0	1	2	3	4
My social circle is not accommodating or considerate of my child's needs.	0	1	2	3	4
Engaging with the community has become increasingly difficult.	0	1	2	3	4
My child's support needs affect their schooling negatively.	0	1	2	3	4
Advocating for my child's needs in social and community settings is overwhelming.	0	1	2	3	4
Community activities or events rarely accommodate my child's special needs.	0	1	2	3	4

Total: _____

5. Financial Strain (12 Questions)

How much do you feel these statements reflect your present situation?

Caring for my child's needs places a significant financial burden on our family.	0	1	2	3	4
Affording resources and support for my child's development is challenging.	0	1	2	3	4
Financial concerns are a major source of stress in our family life.	0	1	2	3	4
I have had to make difficult career or job changes due to my child's needs.	0	1	2	3	4
We struggle to find adequate insurance or financial assistance for my child's care.	0	1	2	3	4
Financial concerns significantly impact our family planning decisions.	0	1	2	3	4
Meeting personal or family needs is difficult due to financial constraints.	0	1	2	3	4
Finding and accessing financial assistance for my child's needs is a complex process.	0	1	2	3	4
The cost of childcare or special education services strains our family budget.	0	1	2	3	4
I am concerned about managing future financial costs related to my child's upbringing.	0	1	2	3	4
We have had to significantly cut back on leisure or non-essential expenses.	0	1	2	3	4
I feel uncertain about our financial ability to provide for my child's long-term needs.	0	1	2	3	4

Total: _____

6. Household Safety_(12 Questions)

How much do you feel these statements reflect your present situation?

I have concerns about the safety of our household environment.	0	1	2	3	4
My child threatens or is physically violent with me or others in my home.	0	1	2	3	4
I feel unprepared for handling emergencies or safety concerns in the home.	0	1	2	3	4
Establishing clear safety rules and boundaries at home is challenging.	0	1	2	3	4
I am constantly worried about the safety of other children in the home.	0	1	2	3	4
Our home lacks necessary equipment or modifications for my child's safety needs.	0	1	2	3	4
Safety concerns significantly restrict family activities at home.	0	1	2	3	4
My child struggles to understand and follow home safety rules.	0	1	2	3	4
Emergency situations at home are common and often poorly managed.	0	1	2	3	4
I frequently need to intervene to prevent accidents or injuries in the home.	0	1	2	3	4
There's a significant need for special safety equipment or modifications in our home.	0	1	2	3	4
My child has difficulty recognizing and responding to safety risks at home.	0	1	2	3	4

Total: _____

Scoring Totals for Support Need Levels

How much do you feel these statements reflect your present situation?

Score Range	Trauma Activation Level	Interpretation	Suggested Next Steps
0–72	<i>Sustained Stability</i>	Few stress indicators. Caregiver feels equipped.	Offer optional reflective tools and light check-ins.
73–144	<i>Emerging Disruption</i>	Moderate strain across multiple domains.	Collaborative care mapping. Peer-led support planning. Invite provider huddle if desired.
145–216	<i>Trauma Activation Present</i>	Caregiver fatigue, emotional exhaustion, or systemic distrust is impairing well-being.	Activate coordinated supports. Consider school advocacy, respite referral, or clinical wraparound.
217–288	<i>Fracture Point / Systemic Harm</i>	Critical trauma patterns. Risk of caregiver collapse or household instability.	Begin intensive care plan development. Safety plan if needed. Prioritize continuity and dignity in all service handoffs.

Safety Domain Override:

If any of these items are scored 3–4, initiate a safety-centered care team conversation regardless of total score.

- “Emergency situations at home are common and often poorly managed.”
- “I feel unprepared for handling emergencies or safety concerns in the home.”
- “I am constantly worried about the safety of other children in the home.”
- “Our home lacks necessary equipment or modifications for my child's safety needs.”
- “My child is physically violent with me or others in my home.”